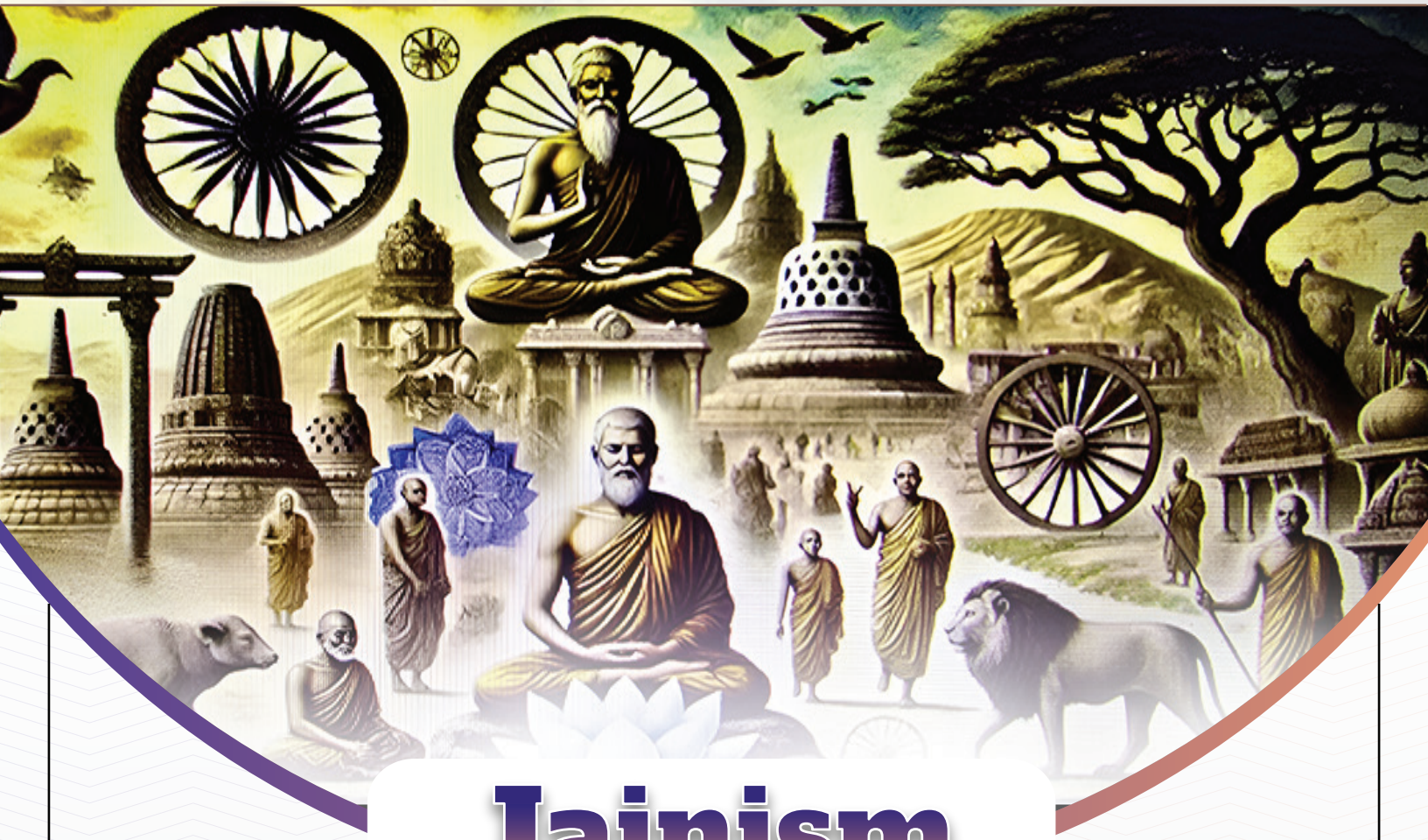
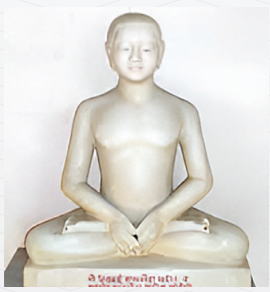


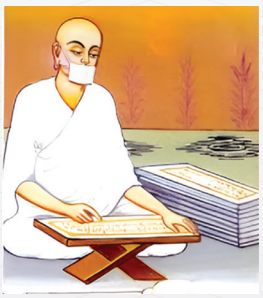
Jainism

Sects of Jainism: Digambara and Shvetambara

Jainism is divided into two major sects: **Digambara (sky-clad)** and **Shvetambara (white-clad)**. Each sect is further subdivided into various sub-sects due to differences in practices, interpretations, and scriptures.

Origins of the Division





- **Time:** 298 BCE, during a 12-year famine in Magadha.
- **Cause:**
  - **Bhadrabahu led a group to South India (Shravan Belgola)** and adhered to stricter practices, including nudity.
  - **Sthulbhadra's group stayed in Magadha,** adopted white clothing, and a less austere lifestyle.

Sect	Digambara	Shvetambara
Foundation	Established by **Bhadrabahu** during the Mauryan period after Jain migration to **South India.**	Established by **Sthulbhadra** in the aftermath of the Jain schism in **Magadha (modern Bihar).**
Teachings & Philosophy	- Follow **Mahavira's Pancha Mahavratas:** Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Brahmacharya, Aparigraha. Emphasize **strict austerity** and renunciation.	- Follow **Parshvanatha's Four Restraints:** Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Aparigraha, with **Brahmacharya** added later. Focus on **moderate rituals** and inclusive practices.
Clothing Practices	- Monks practice **complete nudity,** symbolizing total renunciation. -Female monks **(Aryikas)** wear **plain white sarees**	- Monks and nuns wear **simple white robes,** symbolizing purity and asceticism.
Idol Worship	- Tirthankara idols are **nude, plain, and unadorned.** Eyes are **downcast,** symbolizing meditation and detachment.	- Tirthankara idols are **adorned with jewels and colorful decorations.** Eyes are lively, often decorated with glass.
View on Women	**- Women cannot attain liberation** (salvation) unless reborn as men. Believe **Malli** (19th Tirthankara) was male.	**-Women can attain liberation** and become Tirthankaras. -Believe **Malli** was a female Tirthankara.
Sacred Texts	-Believe the original **Jain scriptures** were lost. -Follow **Prakrit texts** like *Suttapahuda* by Kundakunda.	-Preserve the **Agamas** (12 Angas and Anga-bahyas) as sacred scriptures.
Omniscient Beings	Believe a **Kevali** (omniscient being) no longer requires food.	Reject the belief that **omniscients live without sustenance.**
Philosophical Focus	Emphasize **austerity, renunciation,** and meditation as core principles.	Promote **moderation, inclusion,** and **adaptability** in practices.
Key Temples	**-Shravanabelagola** (Karnataka) - features the giant Bahubali statue. **-Ellora Jain Caves** (Maharashtra). **-Kundalpur** (Madhya Pradesh).	**-Dilwara Temples** (Mount Abu, Rajasthan) - known for exquisite marble work. **-Palitana Temples** (Gujarat) - an important pilgrimage site. **-Shatrunjaya Hills** (Gujarat).

Sub-Sects of Jainism

Sects	Sub-Sects	Key Features
Shvetambara	**Sthanakavasi**	- Reject idol worship: pray to saints. - Saints wear a *muhapatti* (mouth cover).
	Murtipujaka (Deravasi)	- Worship Tirthankara idols in temples. - Saints do not wear a *muhapatti.*
	Terapanthi	- Reject idol worship: pray to saints. - Saints wear a *muhapatti.*
Digambara	**Mula Sangh**	- Oldest sub-sect (c. 430 AD): associated with Acharya Kundakunda. - Divided into branches like Nandi Gana and Sena Gana.
	Bisapantha	- Worship Tirthankaras. Yakshas. and Yakshinis. - Includes *aarti, fruits,* and flower offerings. - Bhattarakas are religious leaders.
	Terapantha	- Worship idols with dry substitutes (no *flowers/fruits*). - Reject Bhattarakas: focus on Tirthankaras.
	Taranapantha	- Reject idol worship but have temples for sacred books. - Emphasize spiritual values and scripture study.
	Others	- Includes Gumanapantha and Totapantha.

Important Jain Practices

Practice	Description
Santhara (Sallekhana	- A voluntary, peaceful death by fasting, undertaken in extreme old age or terminal illness. - Considered an act of spiritual purification and renunciation.
Ahimsa	- Non-violence: central to Jain philosophy, influencing diet (strict vegetarianism) and practices.
Aparigraha	- Non-possessiveness: renouncing material wealth and attachments.
Anuvratas	- Five vows for laypersons: Ahimsa. Satya (truth), Asteya (non-stealing). *Brahmacharya* (celibacy). Aparigraha.
Mahavratas	- Five great vows followed by monks: stricter forms of the Anuvratas.

Jain Literature

Sacred texts were composed in **Ardhamagadhi Prakrit,** later compiled in **Sanskrit** and regional languages.

- **Key Texts:**
  - **12 Angas**
  - **Kalpasutra** (Bhadrabahu): Biographies of Tirthankaras.
  - **Parishishta Parvan** (Hemchandra)
- Jain literature also enriched languages like Kannada, Gujarati, and Marathi.

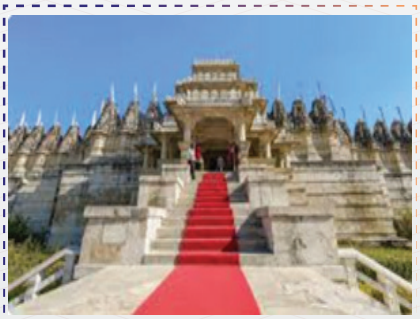
- **Important Jain literatures are:**

Category	Text/Scripture	Author	Description
Canonical Texts	**Agamas**	Compiled by Ganadharas	Sacred texts based on Mahavira's teachings. foundational to Jainism.
	Tattvartha Sutra	Umaswami	Key philosophical text, authoritative for both Svetambara and Digambara.
Svetambara Texts	**Acharanga Sutra**	KshamaShraman Devardhigani	First of the twelve Angas, based on Mahavira's teachings.
	Hemachandra's Yogasastra	Hemachandra	Treatise on conduct for laypeople and ascetics.
Digambara Texts	**Shatkhandagama**	Pushpadanta & Bhutabali	Comprehensive text on karma theory, highly technical.
	Kasayapahuda	Gunabhadra	Treatise on passions, based on Mahavira's teachings.
	Samayasara	Acharya Kundakunda	Expounds Jain concepts like Karma and Moksha.
	Ratnakaranda. Sravakacara	Samantabha dra Swamy	Discusses the conduct of Sravakas (lay followers).
	Sarvarthasiddhi	Pujyapada	Oldest commentary on Tattvartha Sutra.
	Trishasthilkshana Mahapurana	Jinasena & Gunabhadra	Comprehensive Jain history, divided into Adi Purana and Uttara Purana.

Contributions of Jainism

Art and Architecture

- **Caves: Hathigumpha, Udaygiri, Khandagiri** (Orissa).
- **Temples:**
  - **Dilwara Temples** (Mount Abu, Rajasthan)



- **Temples:**
  - **Dilwara Temples** (Mount Abu, Rajasthan)

- **Palitana Temples** (Gujarat)
- **Shravanabelagola:** Gommateshwara statue (Karnataka)
- **Paintings:** The "Western Indian School" developed from Jain manuscript traditions.

Trade and Commerce

- **Jain merchants, guided by non-violence, focused on trade and banking** instead of agriculture or warfare.
- They played significant roles in regional economies.

Conclusion

Jainism, with its emphasis on non-violence, self-discipline, and spiritual liberation, remains a profound influence on Indian culture and values. Its enduring legacy is reflected in its art, ethical principles, and contributions to India's spiritual heritage.

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